wants as it can then create the scare of Muslim consolidation among Hindus."

Congress insiders insist that Hindu-Muslim polarisation is not why they are losing. The real problem, they say, is that, unlike the BJP, which has refined electioneering into a fine art and science, the Congress struggles to project even basic organisational solidity. Both party president Mallikarjun Kharge and organisational secretary K.C. Venugopal are from the South and, critics within the party argue, have little grasp of north India.

Lack of Accountability

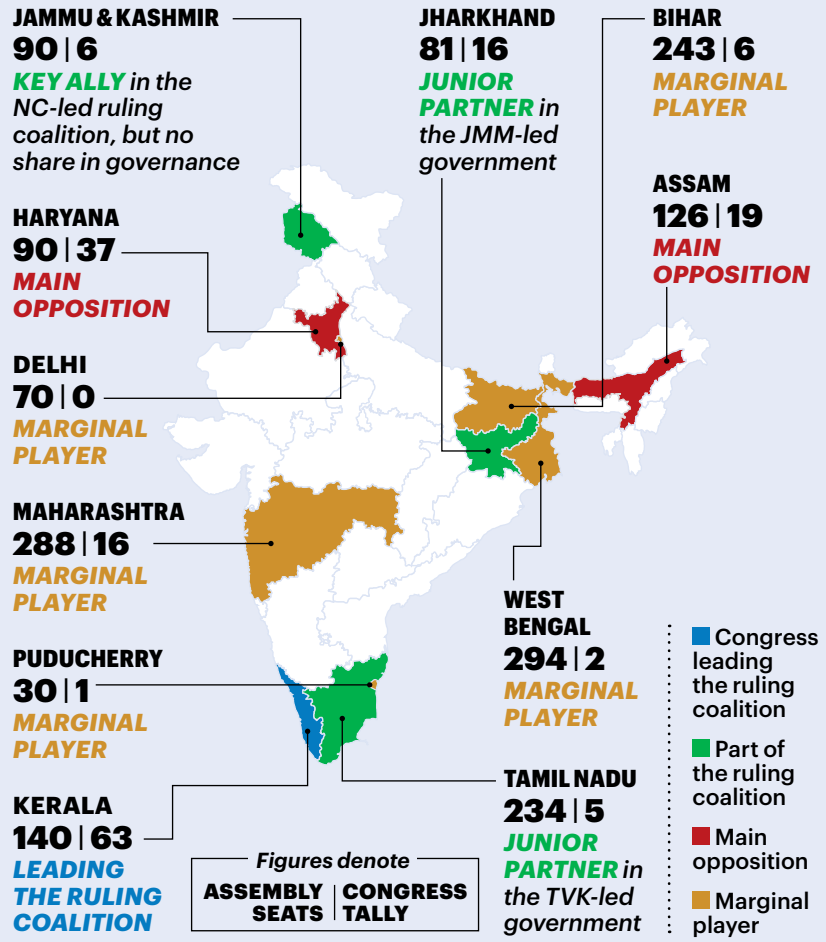
Nor does the party have any meaningful system of accountability. Jitendra Singh remained AICC general secretary in charge of Assam for nearly a decade despite, in the view of one senior leader, lacking the ability to organise campaigns, build cohesion, deploy resources or shape narratives. When Krishna Allavaru, a management consultant-turned-politician, was sent to Bihar to manage the Congress campaign last year, he acknowledged after the defeat that the assignment was outside his experience. The party changed the incharge, appointed a Dalit state president, Rajesh Kumar, and still did not ask either for a plan of action or carry out any structured review.

A pattern runs through the Congress's operational failures: nobody seems to know who decides what. Kharge steps in only on the biggest questions. In Tamil Nadu, he prevailed over Rahul, who wanted to strike a pre-poll alliance with the TVK. Then, there is the tendency of Rahul, Priyanka and Sonia Gandhi to intervene when they want to, not always when the party needs them to. On most organisational matters, the final call thus rests with Venugopal, sometimes because the principals are not speaking directly to one another.

Delay is another recurring problem. "If I had to compress every operational problem in the Congress into one sentence, it would be this: we sit on decisions," says a senior leader. In Kerala, the high command could have told Venugopal months earlier either to contest as the CM face or accept he was out of the race. Instead, the issue drifted until it became a public embarrassment. In Assam, the decision to make Gaurav Gogoi state Congress chief was delayed by at least a year. In Punjab, one of next year's key state elections, no strategic meeting has taken place despite repeated reminders. The party has yet to decide whether state president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring or former CM Charanjit Singh Channi should lead. In Uttarakhand, widely seen as low-

CONGRESS PERFORMANCE SINCE 2024

Since the last Lok Sabha election, assembly polls have been held in 11 states/ UTs. The Congress led the winning alliance only in Kerala, played a junior role in the victorious coalitions in Jammu & Kashmir and Jharkhand, and switched allegiance to the winning side in Tamil Nadu. Outside Kerala, it holds less than 7 per cent of the total assembly seats across the remaining 10 states



Critics within the Congress argue that both party president Mallikarjun Kharge and organisational secretary K.C. Venugopal are from the South and have little grasp of north India